



A COAST GUARD boat scours an area near the Golden Gate Bridge for survivors of Tuesday's accident.

DEATH IN DEEP, CHOPPY S.F. BAY WATERS

Boat was returning from memorial at sea when it sank, killing 1. Three are still missing.

By CLARA HARTER AND JENNY JARVIE

They set out to sea — passing under the Golden Gate Bridge and across the San Francisco Bay to Angel Island — for a memorial service to honor a loved one.

But the voyage 20 family members and friends embarked on Tuesday turned into a tragedy as they headed back to harbor: Their vessel, a 49-foot recreational cruise boat, took on water near Alcatraz Island and began to sink, leaving some passengers clinging to the top deck of the submerged boat while others floated in choppy waters.

Rescuers scrambled to pull 17 passengers to safety Tuesday afternoon, but one person was pronounced dead upon reaching the shore. Three remain missing.

After scouring the inky sea for missing passengers through the night and most of Wednesday, the U.S. Coast Guard announced it would suspend its active search at sunset based on the extensive efforts already conducted and the dwindling probability of locating a survivor.

“Our crews have now been out there for 23 hours straight, they’ve cumulatively covered 950 square nautical miles,” Jarod Toczko, the U.S. Coast Guard’s San Francisco sector commander, said at a Wednesday afternoon news conference. “In addition, they’ve searched over 1,700 miles of track line, utilizing 11 surface assets and four aircraft.”

“We have completely saturated the search area,” [See Boat, A6]

Employers face big jump in prices for healthcare

Insurers expect costs to soar 9% in 2027, driving premiums past \$30,000 for a family.

By MELODY PETERSEN

Employers are bracing for what could be the highest rise in health insurance premiums in 16 years in 2027, driving up the average cost of family coverage in California to more than \$30,000 — the price of a new compact car.

Health insurance companies expect the cost of medical services and prescription drugs to soar by 9% in 2027, according to a new survey by PwC, the highest rise the researchers have found since

2011. Insurers use those expected medical costs to calculate the price of premiums in the coming year. Many employers require workers to pay part of that cost.

Experts say the escalating costs of employers’ premiums are reducing workers’ wages and take-home pay, while raising the prices of goods and services in California and across the country.

“It’s going to erode the standard of living for lots of California families,” said Glenn Melnick, a USC professor of healthcare finance.

Melnick said when employers are forced to spend more on health insurance, there is less money available for wages. The skyrocketing premiums, he said, are like a hidden pay cut for working

families.

The higher cost also has small-business owners wondering whether they can continue paying for their workers’ health insurance.

This year, premiums for staff at the Booksmith, an independent bookstore on Haight Street in San Francisco, leaped by 17%, said Christin Evans, the store’s owner. Next year could bring even more pain. The monthly premium for four employees is \$3,250.

To try to cope, Evans said, she has reduced staff hours by closing the store earlier.

“We have to absorb it,” she said. “We’re not paying the wages we want to pay or delivering the customer service we’d like to deliver.” [See Insurance, A11]

Hot, hard-to-get wedding venues? Public buildings

By SONJA SHARP



SARAHBETH MANEY For The Times
DEMAND for courthouse weddings has boomed since the pandemic.

SANTA BARBARA — The late-morning sun peeked through a gauzy veil of fog, bright laughter echoing over the giddy whisper of tulle as the brides posed for pictures outside the Santa Barbara County Courthouse.

Moments earlier, Zoë Weber and Jordan Cantor of Hollywood had traded vows above the compound’s famous Sunken Garden. The brief, heartfelt legal ceremony was made sweeter because the date, June 26, was the anniversary of the Supreme Court decision that legalized same-sex marriage across the U.S. in 2015.

Minutes before that, their officiant, Santa Barbara County Supervisor Roy Lee, had married off Brittney Hua, 27, and Steven Ly, 26. The Arroyo High School sweethearts made their relationship official that same day 11 years ago, an anniversary that matches their San Gabriel Valley area code, 626.

Lee was soon rushing across the lawn to join Carmen Cardenas Ayon and Santiago Martinez, both 28, who’d come up from Compton for the last-minute wedding of their dreams.

The groom, a bus mechanic, was starting [See Weddings, A6]

Trump overturns suspension of ICE traffic stops

2 killings prompted a halt. Law enforcement experts fault agents’ shooting into cars.

By ANDREA CASTILLO, KEVIN RECTOR AND ANA CEBALLOS

WASHINGTON — U.S. Immigration and Customs Enforcement will continue making arrests during vehicle stops after President Trump said on Wednesday that the agency “CANNOT give up one of I.C.E.’s most important and effective Crime Fighting tools.”

Following two recent fatal shootings by immigration officers, Department of Homeland Security leaders on Tuesday had ordered a pause on vehicle stops pending a review of the incidents and training for agents.

Vehicle stops by ICE have come under criticism not just from immigrant advocates, but from leading law enforcement experts, who say ICE is ignoring best practices in policing.

But on Wednesday, Trump overturned the suspension, the White House confirmed. Giving up traffic stops, Trump wrote on

Truth Social, means “playing right into the criminal’s hands.”

“The Radical Left Democrats would like to see this done, but it won’t happen on my watch,” he added. “I.C.E., be judicious, fair and smart, and go back and do your very important job.”

The shift away from traffic stops came a day after an ICE officer fatally shot a Colombian man in Biddeford, Maine, and a week after an ICE officer fatally shot another man in Houston. Both were driving at the time of the shootings, which extended a fresh wave of criticism over the agency’s enforcement tactics that many condemned earlier this year after the shooting deaths of Alex Pretti and Renee Good in Minneapolis.

The man killed in Maine was Johan Sebastián Durán Guerrero, 26. Last week Lorenzo Salgado Araujo, a 52-year-old from Mexico, was [See ICE, A7]

U.S. intervention in balloting feared

Trump plans speech on “fair elections” tonight. Voting rights advocates are uneasy. NATION, A4

Blanche grilled by Senate committee

One Republican vote against him could block his nomination as attorney general.

By BEN WIEDER

WASHINGTON — Acting Atty. Gen. Todd Blanche faced tough questions from both Republicans and Democrats on the Senate Judiciary Committee on Wednesday as he seeks to make his role permanent.

Blanche was pressed about a settlement agreement between President Trump and the Internal Revenue Service, the Justice Department’s release of the Epstein files, the president’s blanket pardon of violent protesters who breached the U.S. Capitol on Jan. 6, 2021, and actions taken by the department against Trump’s opponents.

As the committee is currently constituted, Blanche would need the support of all Republican members to advance.

Sen. John Cornyn (R-

Texas) told reporters during a break in the hearing that he is still “weighing” whether to support Blanche.

During the hearing, he asked Blanche about the current status of the agreement with the IRS that created a \$1.8-billion “anti-weaponization” fund that could benefit Trump’s allies and granted Trump, two of his sons and his business immunity from tax audits.

“There’s so much that’s unusual about this,” Cornyn said.

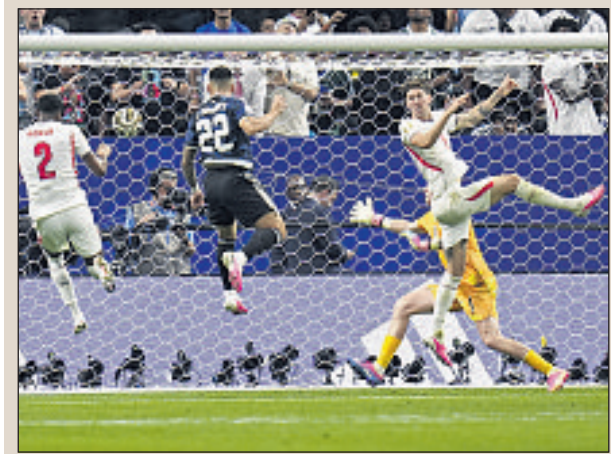
Blanche said that the \$1.8-billion fund is “dead” but conceded that the agreement was still technically alive.

“I’m concerned it’s not dead yet,” Sen. Chris Coons (D-Del.) said later in the hearing.

Blanche demurred when asked by Coons whether he had advised Trump that the settlement was a bad idea.

“I will not talk about communications I had with the president,” Blanche said.

In a scathing ruling this week, the federal judge pre- [See Blanche, A7]



JEFF ROBERSON Associated Press

ARGENTINA TOPS ENGLAND

Lautaro Martinez (22) scores the winning goal two minutes into stoppage time in Argentina’s 2-1 victory over England in Atlanta. SPORTS, B10

DMV suspects 11,000 cheaters

State agency points out irregularities, requiring drivers to retake their written test or lose license. CALIFORNIA, B1

Weather

Mostly sunny and hot. L.A. Basin: 91/69. B6

Markets A11
Opinion Voices A12

Let’s go outside and see a play

Southern California’s beauty sets the stage at these outdoor theaters. ENTERTAINMENT, E1

For the latest news, go to latimes.com.



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The beef over this \$38 brisket sandwich

By STEPHANIE BREIJO

On the plate, it’s a half-pound of Wagyu brisket smothered in pickles and Mornay sauce, all cradled in freshly made pita bread. On the internet, it’s a cultural flash point.

In late June, the viral bas-turma brisket sandwich from Glendale restaurant Yerord Mas found itself at the center of hundreds of comments dissecting cost, tradition and respect after a content creator deemed the

sandwich “not worth” its \$38 price tag.

But it was the influencer’s additional jab of “F— the traditional style” that especially upset Yerord Mas chef-owner Arthur Grigoryan. He called content creator Richie Gaines’ words “offensive” and announced that Yerord Mas would no longer serve the sandwich that L.A. Times restaurant critic Bill Addison, in his review of the restaurant, said was “phenomenal, a statement piece of excess and engineering ... easily enough to

feed two people.”

Days later, after receiving numerous calls, texts and online messages asking him to continue serving the bas-turma sandwich, including from legendary kebab and rotisserie shop Zankou Chicken, Grigoryan decided to keep the sandwich on the menu after all.

The incident brings into stark relief an influencer culture that has set local restaurateurs at odds with content creators.

Instagram, TikTok and Reddit boards are filled with

roughly 1,000 comments regarding the Yerord Mas “ragequit” debate, some criticizing the restaurant and others the influencer.

Gaines said his TikTok post about the sandwich, which has racked up more than 125,500 views, was never intended as a critique of Armenian culture. But Grigoryan said Gaines had echoed a longstanding debate surrounding the cost and “worth” of food that’s traditionally deemed “cheap.”

Admittedly unfamiliar [See Sandwich, A11]